

1 June 2003

Dear Jen,

I feel neglected. I have no idea what is going on or how you are doing and I just want to get some mail when the delivery comes in. It has been nearly a month since I last received any mail at all.

Last night was strange. For the most part, it was a quiet night. It was relatively cool and I did not feel the need to take off my DCU top until fairly late. The day had been hot leading into evening. For once the Colonel and the XO went to bed early, and there was little for us to do other than play Worms and conduct the occasional radio checks. Around 1 am, however, five mortar rounds were fired at our Field Trains. It was the first military action in a while and, I admit, it caught us by surprise. Two rounds landed near the Field Trains. The first landed by the front entrance and the second landed near the command post. One soldier was injured—minor shrapnel wounds to the leg. He had been pulling guard.

Bounty dispatched its Quick Reaction Force (QRF), and we sent out the scouts. As usual, the initial details were vague and difficult to interpret. Captain Wilson was on duty and it was his first “combat” experience in the TOC so he relied heavily on me to get the right information to the right people. It was empowering to be the one controlling a large part of the action on this end. I was amazed at how much I actually knew about TOC operations. We set up several traffic control points and coordinated a series of scout reconnaissance missions, but did not catch the men responsible for the attack. As a result, the Battalion is on a heightened state of alert and we have increased our patrols to cover the entire 24 hours of every day.

Our Brigade, however, is a different story. They are new to theater and it shows. Not only do they seem incapable of figuring out one continuous reporting schedule, but they managed to completely misunderstand the reports that were sent to them this night. In the next Commander’s Update, the Brigade Intelligence Officer had misconstrued all the facts and had suddenly conjured up several separate mortar attacks on different units—all simultaneous no less. It was a classic example of how when you tell one person something, by the time the guy at the other end gets the message, it has been completely altered. Amazing! I guess that is just a product of spending some time over here.

In the next couple of days we will conduct a raid on some illegal weapons markets in our area. It should be interesting since we are working with a Special Forces Unit. They are always very secretive, as if no one is supposed to know what they are doing. The irony of it is that everyone knows who they are and what they are up to. It’s pretty funny.

Anyhow, my workouts continued today. I worked out for almost an hour—chest and triceps. The equipment is limited, but the weight is heavy enough to where you can actually get a good workout. Today I did six sets of flat bench, four sets of incline push ups, and some dumbbell flies. Additionally, I did some skull crushers and several sets of